

It has been shown that during the period 1963-1971 changes in marital fertility accounted for 40 percent of the decline in the crude birth rate.⁶ The remaining 60 percent of the reduction has been attributed to the joint influence of changes in marital composition and age structure of the female population. The changes in marital composition tended to lower the birth rate while the changing age structure tended to raise it. The influence of changes in marital composition outweighed that of the changes in age structure resulting in their jointly accounting for 60 percent of the reduction.

Growth rates by ethnic groups

It is also of interest to consider the rates of growth of the major ethnic groups in the country. Table 2.7 shows the average annual rates of growth of principal ethnic groups for the intercensal periods since 1946.

TABLE 2.7 : AVERAGE ANNUAL RATES OF GROWTH OF MAJOR ETHNIC GROUPS DURING INTERCENSAL PERIODS 1946 - 1971.

	AVERAGE ANNUAL RATE OF GROWTH		
	1946-53	1953-63	1963-71
All Ethnic Groups	2.8	2.7	2.2
Sinhalese	2.8	2.9	2.4
Ceylon Tamils	2.7	2.7	2.4
Indian Tamils	3.2	2.3	-0.3
Ceylon Moors	3.1	3.0	3.5
Indian Moors	4.2	1.5	-8.2
Burghers	1.4	-0.03	-0.14

The rates of growth of the Sinhalese and the Ceylon Tamils have both declined to 2.4 per annum in 1971. The Ceylon Moors have consistently higher rates of growth than both the Sinhalese and the Tamils and furthermore their rate of growth has risen to 3.5 in 1963-71. Indian Tamils and Indian Moors have registered negative growth rates during 1963-71 due to their being repatriated in large numbers. The Burghers, too, show a decline in numbers due to migration out of the country, mostly to Australia. The different rates of growth exhibited by the individual ethnic groups who are not subject to migration in large numbers is, of course, due to the differences in their birth rates and death rates and the resulting rates of natural increase. Table 2.8 shows the average birth, death and natural increase rates for the period 1963-71, both years inclusive, for the main ethnic groups.

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